Course notes

Definition and properties

The exponential is continuous and strictly increasing on $\mathbb{R}$, and its range is $]0,+\infty[$. For every $x>0$, there is a unique real number y such that $e^y=x$: we denote it by $\ln x$.

$$\ln(e^y)=y \quad (y\in\mathbb{R}), \qquad e^{\ln x}=x \quad (x>0), \qquad \ln 1=0, \quad \ln e=1.$$

For $a,b>0$ and $n\in\mathbb{Z}$,

$$\ln(ab)=\ln a+\ln b, \quad \ln\left(\frac{a}{b}\right)=\ln a-\ln b, \quad \ln(a^n)=n\ln a, \quad \ln\sqrt{a}=\tfrac{1}{2}\ln a.$$

Proof of the product rule. $e^{\ln a+\ln b}=e^{\ln a}e^{\ln b}=ab$; the uniqueness of the preimage gives the formula. There is no analogous formula for $\ln(a+b)$.

Derivative, variations and limits

We accept that ln is differentiable on $]0,+\infty[$. Differentiating $e^{\ln x}=x$ gives $e^{\ln x}(\ln x)'=1$; hence $(\ln x)'=\frac{1}{x}>0$. ln is strictly increasing and concave, because its second derivative is $-\frac{1}{x^2}$.

$$\lim_{x\to 0^+}\ln x=-\infty, \qquad \lim_{x\to+\infty}\ln x=+\infty.$$

Its curve is the reflection of that of the exponential in the line $y=x$. The line $x=0$ is a vertical asymptote. Its tangent at 1 gives $\ln x\le x-1$ for $x>0$.

Key point · Composition and comparison of growth rates. If $u>0$ is differentiable, $(\ln u)'=\frac{u'}{u}$. For every integer $m\ge 1$,

$$\lim_{x\to+\infty}\frac{\ln x}{x^m}=0, \qquad \lim_{x\to 0^+}x^m\ln x=0.$$

Proof at 0. Set $t=-\ln x$; as $x\to 0^+$, $t\to+\infty$ and $x\ln x=-te^{-t}\to 0$ by comparison of growth rates. For $m\ge 1$, the same reasoning gives $-te^{-mt}\to 0$. At $+\infty$, set $t=\ln x$ to write $\frac{\ln x}{x^m}=\frac{t}{e^{mt}}\to 0$.

Equations and thresholds

For $A,B>0$, $\ln A=\ln B\Leftrightarrow A=B$ and $\ln A\le\ln B\Leftrightarrow A\le B$. Always start with the domain.

Example. $\ln(x-1)+\ln(x+1)=\ln 8$ requires $x>1$. The equation becomes $x^2-1=8$, so $x=3$ only.

Threshold. $0.8^n \leq 0.1$ is equivalent to $n \ln 0.8 \leq \ln 0.1$, then $n \geq \frac{\ln 0.1}{\ln 0.8} \simeq 10.319$. The first integer is 11.

Example of a study. For $f(x) = \frac{\ln x}{x}$, $f' = \frac{1-\ln x}{x^2}$; f increases on $]0, e]$, decreases on $[e, +\infty[$, and its maximum is $\frac{1}{e}$. Its limit at 0^+ is $-\infty$, its limit at $+\infty$ is 0.

